

What is Agriculture?

The definition of **agriculture** is complicated. At its simplest, agricultural is the large-scale **cultivation** of domesticated plants and/or herding of domesticated animals. Agriculture implies a significant economic role for these domesticated species. But note the language used here: “large-scale” and “significant.” What scale is “large”? What is a “significant” economic role? These definitions are relative, and a little fuzzy, for a reason. As in the present day, the lines between agriculture and not-agriculture were blurry in the past. We can perhaps best think of these as a continuum that involves increasing percentages of domesticated plants and animals in the diet, as well as increasing reliance on cultivated foods (both wild and domesticated) rather than the hunting and gathering of natural populations. Agricultural systems also span a continuum, from farming (reliance on domesticated plants alone) to **pastoralism** (reliance on domesticated animals alone), with varying forms of **agropastoralism** in between.

Cultivation is human intervention in plant life cycles to encourage their growth and productivity for human use. This may be on a small scale, such as clearing away undesirable plants so that a preferred plant can spread. Cultivation appears to have preceded domestication in many parts of the world, but this set of practices ultimately led to the domestication of many cultivated species.

Agriculture is cultivation on a larger scale, typically of domesticated species. Agriculture often describes economic reliance on domesticated species and is typically accompanied by large-scale landscape transformations, as well as economic transformations. Agriculture can include reliance on plants and/or animals,

although reliance on animals without plants is often termed **pastoralism**, and reliance on both plants and animals within a single economy may alternatively be termed **agropastoralism**.

Pastoralism is a form of agriculture in which humans rely heavily or exclusively on the care of domesticated animals. This can include sedentary forms of pastoralism, in which people live in one location and tend animals there, but often includes various types of mobility, in which humans move with animals across the landscape to access different food and water resources for those animals.

Agropastoralism is a form of agriculture in which the cultivation of domesticated plants and herding of domesticated animals both are central to the economy. Agropastoral communities may be sedentary, to enable cultivation of plants; seasonally mobile (moving animals between summer and winter pastures, for example); or segmented, meaning that part of the population moves with animals while others stay in one location to farm.